CHEAT SHEET · KEEP IT NEXT TO YOU

The 30-Second Layoff Answer

What to say when they ask "Why did you leave?" Calm, honest, and finished in half a minute.

1 The formula

What happened
One plain sentence. No warm-up, no apology.

Why it wasn't about you
The scale of the layoff, or one real result.

Where you're going
Why this role. End on the future, then stop talking.

> *"My role was one of about 40 cut in a restructuring in March. In my last year I renegotiated supplier contracts that saved around €200,000. Now I'm looking for a bigger procurement role, and that's exactly what drew me to this one."*

2 Pick your situation

Company-wide layoff
"I was part of a company-wide reduction of [X]% of staff in [month]. Before that I [result]."

Position eliminated
"The company stopped investing in [area], and my position was eliminated as part of that change."

Merger or acquisition
"After [company] was acquired, the teams were merged and my role became a duplicate."

Startup ran out of money
"The startup couldn't close its next funding round and had to cut most of the team."

Only a few people cut
"The team went from [X] to [Y]. They kept the people on the product line they continued. My manager is a reference."

Fired for performance
"Honestly, the role wasn't the right fit. It needed [skill] at a level I didn't have yet. Since then I've [what you did]."

You quit first
"I decided to leave to make my next move on my own terms, and it's let me be selective."

Burnout or health
"I took time off for a personal matter that's fully resolved. I'm rested and ready to get back to [work]."

3 Write yours

4 Explaining the gap

Why there's a gap
One sentence.

What you did
Course, freelance work, volunteering, caregiving, a focused search.

Why you're ready
And why this role.

> *"After the layoff in May, I took a couple of weeks to reset and then started a focused search. I've also completed [course]. My skills are current, and I'm ready to commit to the right team."*

5 Say this, not that

Instead of…	Say…
"Unfortunately, they let me go…"	"My role was eliminated in [month]."
"Management was terrible."	"The company changed direction."
"I'll take anything."	"I've been selective. This role stood out because…"
"I really need this job."	"I'm really interested in this role."
"I'm not sure why they picked me."	"Decisions were based on [criteria]."
"I've just been sitting at home."	"I've been focused on my search and on [course]."

6 Three questions to ask them

- What would a great first three months look like in this role?
- What's the biggest challenge the person in this job will face?
- Is there anything about my background that makes you hesitate? I'd like the chance to address it.

7 Five minutes before you walk in

- [ ] Say your 30-second answer out loud once
- [ ] Read three things you're proud of from your last job
- [ ] Remember: after a good answer, pause. Silence is confidence.
- [ ] Never criticise your old employer
- [ ] End every answer on the future

Want the full plan? *Laid Off to Interview-Ready in 30 Days* has 12 exit scripts, résumé-gap answers, 14 tough follow-up questions, a day-by-day plan and printable worksheets. Find it in the VizoraCareers shop.

General interview advice; adapt every script so it is true for you. For personal use only.